The Bilal Morning

Friday, 16 October 2026 BACKFILLED EDITION 12 stories · 14 sources

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THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. Portable smart telescopes help stargazers view detailed deep-space objects away from light pollution.
2. Researchers discovered that dead white dwarf stars can take on a green hue when consuming rocky planets.
3. Vaonis unveiled the Atlas, the world's first modular smart telescope system with interchangeable optical tubes.

Beat Light Pollution With Portable Telescopes for Clearer Night Skies

Traveling away from suburban light pollution with portable smart telescopes helps stargazers view detailed deep-space objects without skyglow obstruction.

- Skyglow significantly impedes deep-space stargazing, making darker skies or smart equipment necessary for clear observations. [space.com]

  > “Light pollution is the astronomer's biggest enemy, especially if you're gazing into deep space.”

- Moving out of suburban areas allows observers to see celestial bodies with far higher clarity. [space.com]

  > “Galaxies, nebulas and other deep space objects become more detailed when they're not washed out by skyglow.”

- Five of the six recommended portable models feature smart capabilities that allow users to select targets from a list. [space.com]

  > “All but one are smart telescopes, meaning that when you do get to your desired location, you can pick from a list of stellar sights to home in on.”

In the image: The image shows a sleek, white and black smart telescope on a small tripod with "VESPERA II" printed vertically on its side.

✓ 3 of 3 claims verified against sources · 1 source

space.com

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ASTRONOMY AND ASTROPHYSICS



In the image: The image illustrates a glowing green white dwarf star accreting planetary debris and rocky material from an orbiting planetary companion in deep space.

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Astronomers Discover the First-Ever Green Star, a Cosmic Zombie

Researchers found that dead white dwarf stars can take on a ghostly green hue when they consume surrounding rocky planets.

- White dwarfs can display a variety of unexpected colors like green and pink when they interact with planetary debris. [space.com]

  > "it turns out that scientists have discovered that our star may indeed go green, but only billions of years from now after its death — and only if it then starts eating planets like a cosmic zombie."

- The white dwarf WD J1330+6435 is identified as the first known green star due to sodium traces in its atmosphere. [space.com]

  > "The traces of sodium in the atmosphere of this white dwarf absorb the orange part of the spectrum, leaving behind a ghostly green glow."

- Scientists estimate that approximately one in thirty white dwarfs across the universe possesses an unusual, non-white color. [space.com]

  > "Extrapolating this to the total population of white dwarfs, the team estimates that only one in 30 of these dead stars has an unusual color."

Vaonis Announces Atlas, the World's First Modular Smart Telescope System

Vaonis has unveiled the Atlas, a modular smart telescope system featuring interchangeable optical tubes and live night sky monitoring.

- Vaonis has announced the Atlas, the world's first modular smart telescope system designed for interchangeability and adaptability. [space.com]

  > "Vaonis unveils Atlas, the world's 1st modular smart telescope system"

- The SkyDock system features two ports allowing users to connect dual optical tubes and future imaging modules. [space.com]

  > "Its new SkyDock system allows two optical tubes to be connected and the telescope has live night sky monitoring"

- The initial Atlas 80 module includes an 80mm aperture and a Sony sensor, with planetary modules planned for future release. [space.com]

  > "The Atlas 80 imaging module is an optical tube with a 3.15-in (80 mm) aperture and a Sony IMX585 8.3MP sensor"

- Pre-orders are currently open, with shipments expected to begin in March 2027. [space.com]

  > "Atlas pre-orders open today and are available from BH Photo and Video and Adorama. The special preorder pricing is available until Nov. 15, with the

> First shipments expected in March 2027.”

In the image: The image shows a close-up of the Atlas 80 optical tube lens and casing, highlighting the aperture size, focal length, and 'APO Quadruplet' specifications.

✓ 4 of 4 claims verified against sources · 1 source

space.com

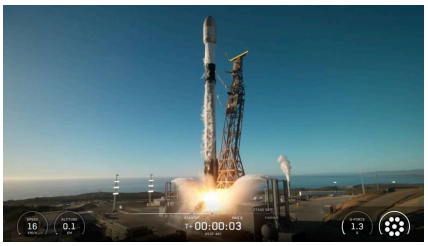
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Mystery as NASA probe spots huge UFO zooming past the sun at 'near light speed'

dailymail.com

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SPACE EXPLORATION



SpaceX Launches Classified USSF-481 Mission from California

A Falcon 9 rocket successfully lifted off from Vandenberg Space Force Base, carrying a classified payload for the U.S. Space Force.

- SpaceX launched a classified U.S. Space Force mission from Vandenberg Space Force Base in California on October 15. [space.com]

  > "SpaceX launched a classified mission for the U.S. Space Force from California this evening (Oct. 15)."

- The Falcon 9 rocket lifted off at 8:01 p.m. EDT into clear blue skies. [space.com]

  > "A Falcon 9 rocket lifted off from Vandenberg Space Force Base today at 8:01 p.m. EDT"

- The mission, designated USSF-481, delivered mysterious payloads to an undisclosed location.

  [space.com]

  > "This evening's launch kicked off the USSF-481 mission, which is delivering mysterious payloads to an undisclosed location"

- The first stage booster successfully landed on a drone ship in the Pacific Ocean about 8.5 minutes after launch. [space.com]

  > "landing, which occurred as planned about 8.5 minutes after launch on the drone ship"

- This flight marked the 28th launch for booster 1081.

  [space.com]

  > "USSF-481 was the 28th flight for this particular booster, which is designated 1081."

In the image: The image provides a real-time visual of the Falcon 9 liftoff from the launch pad, including overlay telemetry data such as speed, altitude, and G-force.

✓ 5 of 5 claims verified against sources · 1 source

space.com

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NASA Launches Cassini-Huygens Probe to Saturn

On October 15, 1997, NASA launched the Cassini spacecraft aboard a Titan 4B rocket to begin a landmark 20-year mission exploring Saturn and its moons.

- On October 15, 1997, NASA launched the Cassini spacecraft toward Saturn from Cape Canaveral.

  [space.com]

  > "On Oct. 15, 1997, NASA launched the Cassini spacecraft on a mission to explore Saturn and its moons."

- The spacecraft lifted off using a Titan 4B rocket in Florida. [space.com]

  > "It lifted off aboard a Titan 4B rocket from Cape Canaveral Air Force Station in Florida."

- The Huygens lander traveled with Cassini and landed on the moon Titan in 2005.

  [space.com]

  > "Another smaller spacecraft called Huygens hitched a ride with Cassini, and it landed on Saturn's moon Titan in 2005."

- Cassini intentionally ended its mission by diving into Saturn's atmosphere in 2017 to protect pristine moons.

  [space.com]

  > "Running low on fuel, NASA chose to steer Cassini straight into Saturn's atmosphere, where the spacecraft was destroyed."

In the image: The image shows the nighttime launch of the rocket carrying the Cassini-Huygens probe with massive illumination and exhaust plumes, which is not depicted in the text.

✓ 4 of 4 claims verified against sources · 1 source

space.com

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SpaceX Cargo Dragon Docks with ISS to Deliver Supplies

The CRS-35 mission delivered over 6,300 pounds of food, research equipment, and hardware to the International Space Station.

- The SpaceX Dragon spacecraft docked autonomously with the ISS on Thursday morning. [space.com][thepeninsulaqatar.com]

  > “The Dragon spacecraft docked autonomously with the ISS at 10:27am Eastern Time (1427 GMT) on Thursday.”

- The cargo includes food, research equipment, and hardware to support the station's newest crew members. [space.com]

  > “Dragon's arrival brings more than 6,300 pounds (2,860 kilograms) of food, research equipment and other supplies”

- Launched from Cape Canaveral Space Force Station in Florida on Tuesday, the mission is SpaceX's 35th commercial resupply services mission. [space.com][thepeninsulaqatar.com]

  > “SpaceX's cargo Dragon, flying the CRS-35 (35th Commercial Resupply Services) mission for NASA, rendezvoused with the International Space Station (ISS) this morning”

- Dragon will remain at the station for about a month before returning to Earth with research and cargo. [space.com][thepeninsulaqatar.com]

  > “It will remain docked with the ISS for about a month before being packed with supplies, waste and research for its return”

- return to Earth via a splashdown off the coast of California. [thepeninsulaqatar.com]

  > “returning to Earth with time-sensitive research and cargo, splashing down off the coast of California.”

In the image: The image shows the docking mechanism and open hatch of the SpaceX Cargo Dragon spacecraft as it approaches the ISS.

✓ 5 of 5 claims verified against sources · 2 sources

space.com · thepeninsulaqatar.com

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China Successfully Launches Zhuque-2E Rocket with Ten Satellites

China successfully launched a Zhuque-2E Y4 carrier rocket from the Dongfeng commercial space innovation pilot zone, deploying ten satellites into preset orbits.

- China launched a Zhuque-2E Y4 carrier rocket from the Dongfeng commercial space innovation pilot zone. [en.people.cn][china.org.cn]

  > “China successfully launched a Zhuque-2E Y4 carrier rocket from the Dongfeng commercial space innovation pilot zone”

- The rocket lifted off at 7:40 p.m. Beijing Time and successfully deployed ten satellites. [en.people.cn] [china.org.cn]

  > “The rocket lifted off at 7:40 p.m. (Beijing Time) and deployed 10 satellites into their preset orbits.”

- Eight of the launched satellites belong to the 02 group of ADAspace's 'star compute' plan. [en.people.cn] [china.org.cn]

  > “Eight satellites of the 02 group of a "star compute" plan, developed by Adaspace Technology Co., Ltd. (ADAspace)”

- The 'star compute' plan aims to build AI space infrastructure using 2,800 computing satellites. [en.people.cn][china.org.cn]

  > “The "star compute" plan is an ambitious project by the company to build AI space infrastructure composed of 2,800 computing satellites.”

✓ 4 of 4 claims verified against sources · 2 sources

en.people.cn · china.org.cn

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Chetan Sharma Backs Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli for 2027 World Cup

Former cricketer Chetan Sharma argued that performance matters more than age discussions regarding Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli's prospects for the 2027 ODI World Cup.

- Chetan Sharma stated that age is irrelevant if players perform well.

  [cambodiantimes.com]

  > “Age is just a number. If you're performing well, like both Virat and Rohit scored centuries”

- Sharma expressed support for veteran fast bowler Bhuvneshwar Kumar's return to the T20I squad.

  [cambodiantimes.com]

  > “Bhuvneshwar has worked really hard. He's bowling brilliantly. I'm a witness to it.”

- The former cricketer called for balanced pitches to help bowlers compete more fairly against batters.

  [cambodiantimes.com]

  > “I know the public wants to see fours and sixes, but please pay a little attention to the bowlers too.”

- Sharma warned young cricketers against tournaments that charge registration fees without helping player development.

  [cambodiantimes.com]

  > “Some people and companies take money from kids through registration fees and don't give anything back into cricket.”

In the image: Chetan Sharma speaking into a microphone during an interview.

✓ 4 of 4 claims verified against sources · 1 source

cambodiantimes.com

You engaged with 1 of 2 Cricket stories you saw



China and Pakistan Launch Joint Military Drills to Test Combat Readiness

China and Pakistan have begun their first joint army training exercises in Xinjiang, raising strategic concerns for India and deepening bilateral military cooperation.

- China and Pakistan launched their first joint army training, known as Karakoram-2026, in the Xinjiang region.

  [theepochtimes.com]

  > “Beijing and Islamabad launched their first joint army training on Oct. 14”

- The military exercises focus on high-altitude counterterrorism sweeps, drone operations, and joint command maneuvers.

  [theepochtimes.com]

  > “exercises will center on high-altitude counterterrorism sweeps, including drone operations and joint command maneuvers”

- Analysts suggest the drills are designed to pile strategic pressure on India and demonstrate combat capabilities. [theepochtimes.com]

  > “China is using army exercises with Pakistan to train its forces under realistic combat conditions while piling pressure on India from two sides”

In the image: A family rides a motorcycle past street decorations featuring the flags of China and Pakistan in Lahore.

✓ 3 of 4 claims verified against sources · 1 source

theepochtimes.com

You engaged with 2 of 5 Pakistan cricket team stories you saw



Archbishop Coakley urges Catholics to put faith before politics in midterms

Ahead of the November midterm elections, Archbishop Paul S. Coakley reminded the faithful that voting is both a right and a responsibility.

- Ahead of the midterm elections, Archbishop Paul S. Coakley issued a statement emphasizing that voting is both a right and a responsibility. [cathstan.org]

  > “participation in public life -- including voting -- is both a right and a responsibility.”

- The archbishop addressed political divisions and urged Catholics not to give in to discouragement during the election process. [cathstan.org]

  > “In a time of deep political division, the temptation is to be discouraged and to not participate in the election process.”

- Archbishop Coakley called on voters to evaluate candidates based on their actual actions rather than their campaign promises. [cathstan.org]

  > “I encourage all to judge candidates and elected officials by their actions, not merely their promises”

- A recent Pew Research Center survey showed a decline in approval ratings for President Donald Trump among various Catholic groups leading up to October 2026. [cathstan.org]

  > “President Donald Trump’s approval rating dropped from 47% at the beginning of his second term to 30% in October 2026.”

In the image: A voter drops an official ballot into a drop box from their car window, illustrating the voting process discussed in the text.

✓ 4 of 4 claims verified against sources · 1 source

cathstan.org

Exploring: a Politics story outside your usual topics, to learn whether you want more

EDUCATION



Johnson County Private Schools See Growth Amid Public Enrollment Declines

While public schools face enrollment drops, private schools in Johnson County like St. Thomas Aquinas are experiencing stable or growing student populations.

- Private school enrollment across the country was five percent higher in 2021 than in 2011, according to the National Center for Education Statistics. [kshb.com]

  > “That data reportedly indicated private school enrollment nationwide was five percent higher than it was in 2011.”

- St. Thomas Aquinas President Brian Schenck noted that the school has experienced an increase in enrollment since the pandemic. [kshb.com]

  > “"Ever since COVID, we had an enrollment increase," Brian Schenck said.”

- Joshua Cox and his family shifted from public to private schooling in 2018 to gain more community and a voice in their children's education. [kshb.com]

  > “Cox said the family wanted more community and more of a say in their children's education.”

- Schenck explained that private schools do not attempt to serve every possible need, which helps set them apart from public education. [kshb.com]

  > “"Public schools do a good job to try to be everything to everybody. We're not going to be everything to everybody.”"

In the image: The image shows KSHB 41 reporter Olivia Acree conducting an interview with St. Thomas Aquinas President Brian Schenck inside a home.

✓ 4 of 4 claims verified against sources · 1 source

kshb.com

Exploring: a Education story outside your usual topics, to learn whether you want more

You're caught up.

That's today's paper. Your next edition arrives tomorrow morning.